For Whom the Southern Belle Tolls

By Christopher Durang

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR:*** *Lawrence* ***ACTRESS:*** *Amanda, Ginny*

AMANDA: **(Pg 12-13)** Rise and shine! Rise and shine! *(Calls off)* Lawrence, honey, come on out here and let me have a look at you! *(Enter LAWRENCE, who limps across the room. He is very sensitive and is wearing what are clearly his dress clothes. AMANDA fiddles with his bow tie and stands back to admire him.)*

AMANDA: Lawrence, honey, you look lovely.

LAWRENCE: No, I don't mama. I have a pimple on the back of my neck.

AMANDA: Don't say the word "pimple," honey, it's common. Now your brother Tom is bringing home a girl from the warehouse for you to meet, and I want you to make a good impression, honey.

LAWRENCE: I don't need to meet people, mama. I'm happy just by myself, playing with my collection of glass cocktail stirrers. *(LAWRENCE limps over to a table on top of which sits a glass jar filled with glass swizzle sticks)* Each one of them has a special name, mama. This one is called Stringbean because it's long and thin; and this one is called Stringbean because it's long and thin; and this one is called Blue because it's blue.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Welcome to a twisted sendup of Tennessee Williams' The Glass Menagerie!*
ACTOR: *For Whom the Southern Belle Tolls by Christopher Durang*

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AMANDA: **(Pg 13)** Oh, Lawrence honey, how are you going to get on in the world if you just stay home all day, year after year, playing with your collection of glass cocktail stirrers?

LAWRENCE: I don't like the world, mama, I like it here in this room.

AMANDA: I know you do, Lawrence honey, that's part of you charm. Some days. But, honey, what about making a living?

LAWRENCE: I can't work, mama. I'm crippled.

AMANDA: *(Firmly)* There is nothing wrong with your leg, Lawrence, all the doctors have told you that. This limping thing is an ***affectation***.

LAWRENCE: I only know how I feel, mama. You know I have asthma.

AMANDA: Your asthma, your leg, your eczema. You're just a mess, Lawrence!

LAWRENCE: I have scabs from the itching, mama.

AMANDA: Now, Lawrence, I don't want you talking about your ailments to the feminine caller. No nice-bred young lady likes to hear a young man discussing his eczema, Lawrence.

LAWRENCE: What else can I talk about, mama? **(Pg 14-15)** I don't know if I want to meet some girl who works in a warehouse, mama.

AMANDA: Your brother Tom says she's a lovely girl with a nice personality.

LAWRENCE: It's unfeminine for a girl to work at a warehouse.

AMANDA: *(Firm, frustrated)* Lawrence, honey, if you can't go out the door without getting an upset stomach or an attack of vertigo, then we got to find some nice girl who's willing to support you. Otherwise, how am I ever going to get you out of this house and off my hands?

LAWRENCE: *(sensitive, unknowing)* Why do you want to be rid of me, mama?

AMANDA: I suppose it's unmotherly of me, dear, but you really get on my nerves. Limping around the apartment, pretending to have asthma. If only some nice girl would marry you and I knew you were taken care of, then I'd feel free to start to live again. I'm not bitter, dear, it's just that I hate my life. *(Knock at the door)*

LAWRENCE: I'll be in the other room. *(Starts to limp away)*

AMANDA: I want you to let *her* in, Lawrence.

LAWRENCE: Oh, I couldn't mama. She'd see I limp.

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AMANDA: Then don't limp, damn it. Now, Lawrence, you march over to that door or I'm going to break all your swizzle sticks.

LAWRENCE: Mama, I can't! My eczema itches. Excuse me. I think I hear someone calling me in the other room. *(Limps off, calls to imaginary person)* Coming! *(AMANDA opens door)*

GINNY: *(Very friendly, and very loud)* CALL ME GINNY OR GIN! BUT JUST DON'T CALL ME "LATE FOR DINNER"!! *(Roars with laughter)*

AMANDA: Oh, how amusing. *(To herself)* Why is she shouting?

GINNY: **(Pg 16)** I am taking a course in public speaking, and so far we've covered speaking good and loud so the people in the back of the room can hear you.

AMANDA: Public speaking. How impressive. You must be interested in improving yourself.

GINNY: *(Loudly and happily)* YES I AM!

AMANDA: Dinner is almost ready, Ginny.

GINNY: Oh good. I'm as hungry as a bear! *(Growls enthusiastically)*

AMANDA: *(Sarcastically)* You must be very ***popular*** at the warehouse, Ginny. Let me see if I can convince Lawrence to come out here and make conversation with you. *(From off-stage)* **(Pg 17)** Now you get out of that bed this minute, Lawrence Wingvalley, or I'm going to give that overbearing girl your ***entire*** collection of glass gobbledygook - is that clear? *(AMANDA pushes in LAWRENCE)* I believe Lawrence would like to visit with you, Ginny. *(Amanda exits, but spies from off stage)(LAWRENCE stands still, uncomfortable. GINNY looks at him pleasantly)*

GINNY: **(Pg 18-19)** *(Loudly)* HI.

LAWRENCE: Hi . . .

GINNY: Why are you wearing that nightshirt?

LAWRENCE: I'd gone to bed. I wasn't feeling well. My leg hurts and I have a headache, and I have palpitations of the heart. *(Beat)* We've met before, you know. We were in high school together. You were voted Girl Most Likely To Succeed. We sat next to one another in glee club.

GINNY: I'm sorry, I really can't hear you. You're talking too softly.

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LAWRENCE: *(Louder)* You used to call me BLUE ROSES.

GINNY: Blue Roses? Oh yes, I remember, sort of. Why did I do that?

LAWRENCE: I had been absent from school for several months, and when I came back, you asked me where I'd been, and I said I'd been sick with viral pneumonia, but you thought I said "blue roses."

GINNY: I remember you now. You used to make a spectacle of yourself every day in glee class, clumping up the aisle with this great big noisy leg brace on you leg. God, you made a racket.

LAWRENCE: I was always so afraid people were looking at me, and pointing. But then eventually mama wouldn't let me wear the leg brace anymore. She gave it to the Salvation Army. *(Awkward pause)* You want to see my collection of glass cocktail stirrers? (*He limps to the table, and limps back to her, holding his collection)* I call this one Stringbean, because it's long and thin. They're my favorite thing in the world. *(Holds up another one)* I call this one Q-tip, because I realized it looks like a Q-tip, except it's made out of glass and doesn't have little cotton swabs at the end of it. *(She looks blank)* Q- TIPS.

GINNY: Really? *(She takes it and puts it in her ear)*

LAWRENCE: No! Don't put it in your ear. *(Takes it back)* Now it's disgusting.

GINNY: Well, I didn't think it was a Q-tip, but that's what you said it was.

LAWRENCE: I call it that. I think I'm going to throw it out now. *(Holds up another one)* I call this one Pinocchio because if you hold it perpendicular to your nose it makes your nose look long. *(He holds it to his nose)*

GINNY: Uh huh. I know you're tired, I figured that's why you put on the night shirt, but this won't take long. I judge you to be lacking in self-confidence. Am I right?

LAWRENCE: Well, I am afraid of people and things, and I have a lot of ailments.

GINNY: But that makes you special, Lawrence. **(Pg 20)** And that's why you should present yourself with more confidence. Throw back your shoulders, and say, "HI! HOW YA DOIN'?" Now you try it.

LAWRENCE: *(Unenthusiastically, softly)* Hello. How are you?

GINNY: *(Booming)* "HI! HOW YA DOIN'?"

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LAWRENCE: Hi. Howya doin'?

GINNY: Now swagger a bit. *(Kinda butch)* HI. HOWYA DOIN'?

LAWRENCE: *(Imitates her fairly successfully)* HI. HOW YA DOIN'?

GINNY: Good, Lawrence. That's much better. Again. HI! HOW YA DOIN'?

LAWRENCE: HI! HOWYADOIN'?

GINNY: THE BRAVES PLAYED A HELLUVA GAME, DON'TCHA THINK?

LAWRENCE: THE BRAVES PLAYED A HELLUVA GAME, DON'TCHA THINK?

AMANDA: *(Off-stage)* Oh God I feel sorry for their children. *(Amanda enters to put a stop to this)*

GINNY: HI, MRS. WINGVALLEY. YOUR SON LAWRENCE AND I ARE GETTING ON JUST FINE. AREN'T WE, LAWRENCE?

AMANDA: Please, no need to shout. I'm glad you like Lawrence.

GINNY: What?

AMANDA: WHY DON'T YOU MARRY LAWRENCE?

LAWRENCE: Oh, mama.

GINNY: *(Looks shocked)* Oh dear. Mrs. Wingvalley, if I had a young brother as nice and as special as Lawrence is, I'd invite girls from the warehouse home to meet him too. **(Pg 21)** But I'm afraid I won't be calling on Lawrence again.

LAWRENCE: This is so embarrassing. I told you I wanted to stay in my room.

GINNY: But, Lawrence, I don't want you to think that I won't be calling because I don't like you. I do like you.

LAWRENCE: *(Looking hopeful)* You do?

GINNY: Sure. I like everybody. But I'm involved with a girl named Betty. We've been going together for about a year. We're saving money so that we can buy a farmhouse and tractor together. No hard feelings, Lawrence. You're a good kid.

LAWRENCE: *(Offers her a swizzle stick)* I want you to keep this. It's my very favorite one. I call it Thermometer because it looks like a thermometer.

GINNY: You want me to have this? *(She drops the offered gift)*

LAWRENCE: *(Horrified)* You've broken it! **(Pg 22)** YOU'VE BROKEN THERMOMETER!

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GINNY: So, I've broken it. Big deal. You have twenty more of them here. What was a thermometer doing in with the swizzle sticks anyway?

LAWRENCE: Its name was Thermometer, you nitwit!

GINNY: *(Cheerful, her basic nature)* Well, so long, everybody! I had a nice time. *(Exits)*

AMANDA: **(Pg 24)** Oh Lawrence, honey, what's to become of us?

LAWRENCE: **(Pg 25-26)** Oh, poor mama, let me try to cheer you up with my collection. *(Holds up a yellow swizzle stick)* I call this one Daffodil, because its yellow, and daffodils are yellow.

AMANDA: Uh huh.

LAWRENCE: *(Holds up another one)* And I call this one Curtain Rod because it reminds me of a curtain rod.

AMANDA: Uh huh.

LAWRENCE: *(Holds up another one)* And I call this one Ocean, because it's blue, and the ocean is . . .

AMANDA: I THOUGHT YOU CALLED THE BLUE ONE BLUE, YOU IDIOT CHILD! DO I HAVE TO LISTEN TO THIS PATHETIC PRATILING THE REST OF MY LIFE??? CAN'T YOU AT LEAST BE CONSISTENT???

LAWRENCE: *(Hurt)* No, I guess I can't. *(Silence – Amanda looks a t Lawrence and feels bad for yelling at him. She decides to try to make up)*

AMANDA: Do you have any other swizzle sticks with names, Lawrence?

LAWRENCE: Yes, I do. *(Holds one up)* I call this one "Mama." *(He throws it viciously onto the floor)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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